

The Five-Prompt Recon Pattern

One escalating conversation that turns two raw exports into a classified, materiality-tiered break list. Works on any two-sided reconciliation: positions, cash, dividends, withholding. Fill the **<blanks>** with your own table and column names.

BEFORE YOU START · Load both files as named Tables (`tblA` = source side, `tblB` = target side) · format key columns as **Text** so leading zeros survive · keep only this workbook open.

1 Aggregate · "How big is the book?"

In `{tblB}`, total the `{Amount column}` by `{Key column}` and show me the grand total.

You get: the size of the problem, per-key subtotals, and usually a concentration insight for free.

2 Compare · "Where do the numbers differ?"

Compare total `{units}` per `{key}` between `{tblA}` (column "`{KeyA}`" = key, column "`{QtyA}`" = units) and `{tblB}` (column "`{KeyB}`" = key, column "`{QtyB}`" = units). Show me every `{key}` where the totals don't match.

You get: the full mismatch list. Name the columns explicitly, exactly as shown; this is what makes cross-table prompts reliable.

3 Population diff · "What's missing from each side?"

Of those mismatches, which `{keys}` appear only in `{tblA}` with zero in `{tblB}`, and which appear only in `{tblB}` with zero in `{tblA}`?

You get: one-sided items separated from quantity breaks. This is where corporate-action pairs hide in plain sight.

4 Completeness · "Which rows are missing the critical field?"

In `{tblB}`, flag every row where `{critical field}` is blank or empty. Group by `{key}` and show me the total `{units}` affected.

You get: the true exception population, with whatever status pattern explains it.

5 Classify & tier · "What kind of break is each?"

For every `{key}` that isn't a clean match, classify it as one of: `{your break categories}`. Estimate the dollar impact using the average `{amount}` per `{unit}` from `{tblB}`. Mark it "Material" if the estimate exceeds `{threshold}`.

You get: a classified, tiered break list. Expect to correct at least one classification yourself. That is the next page.

The order is the method. Each answer feeds the next prompt, and you size the whole problem before touching any detail. Skipping ahead is how you end up investigating a break that was a corporate action all along.

Steering With Domain Context

The AI matches numbers. Your corporate-action history, your waive conventions, and your judgment live with you until you say them out loud. Steering is how they get in.

- 1

State what you know as fact, not as a question.
"These two rows are the same position before and after a corporate action." Declarative context beats "could these be related?"
- 2

Name the exact rows.
Identifiers, not vibes. Quote the keys (CUSIPs, account numbers) so nothing else gets swept up in the change.
- 3

One steering fact per prompt, then verify.
Stack corrections one at a time and check the table after each. A pile of facts in one prompt is how quiet mistakes get in.

WORKED EXAMPLE · THE NUDGE FROM THE LIVE DEMO

Barrick Gold Corp (067901108) and Barrick Mining Corp (06849F108) are the same position before and after a corporate action. Treat them as a reclassification, not two separate breaks. Same for Medtronic Inc. (585055106) and Medtronic plc (G5960L103). Reclassify those four rows as "Corporate Action – Waive" and update the table.

Fact stated, rows named, change specified. Four rows move, nothing else does, and the material break count drops accordingly.

The pattern does the grunt work. The steering is where the analyst earns the seat.